At his Civil Lines residence in Chhattisgarh capital Raipur, Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel sits at the head of the largish dining table, awaiting his brunch. The 62-year-old is flanked by his top advisors—Vinod Verma and Rajesh Tiwari—and a visitor, Congress leader Rajeev Shukla. Minutes later, over local staples such as baati, white butter, chutneys and fruits, Team Baghel discusses plans for the crunch overs—the last four days of campaigning. The second phase of polling for the remaining 70 seats out of the total of 90 is on November 17.

"All my life, my breakfast has been what I'm having today. It's election time, and my schedule has gone for a six. But in my youth, I went to the local lake for a bath, returned home to have breakfast served by my mother, and then went straight to the farms, only to return in the evening. Nothing has changed," says Baghel, wearing his 'Chhattisgarhiat' on his sleeve. The 'Chhattisgarhi' way of life is a critical part of the Congress campaign led by Baghel and was deployed apparently to counter the BJP's Hindutva pitch.

But what about the corruption allegations surrounding coal transportation, liquor and the Mahadev App against him and his associates? "I have almost become used to them. The ED (Enforcement Directorate), which works for the BJP, has been at it for the past three years." Baghel's deputy secretary Saumya Chaurasia and IAS officers Ranu Sahu and Sameer Vishnoi are in jail. Earlier this month, the ED claimed that a cash stash recovered in Raipur was meant for a certain 'Baghel'. There is also a video in circulation featuring an individual identifying himself as Shubham Soni, claiming to be the original owner of the Mahadev App—currently being probed by the ED for its involvement in a betting racket. Soni alleges he was packed off to Dubai and his business taken over by Baghel and his men. Baghel's advisor Verma has issued a legal notice to BJP spokespersons who suggested that the person being mentioned in the video was him. Will the ED arrest him too? "They can do anything. They work outside the Constitution," says Baghel.

Missing in 2023 compared to 2018—when the Congress swept to power—is the camaraderie between his one-time comrade-in-arms deputy CM T.S. Singhdeo, home minister Tamradhwaj Sahu and speaker Charandas Mahant. Does he feel alone this time? Will it impact the outcome of the polls, given that there is talk of compromised ticket distribution owing to factionalism? Congress leaders in the state feel that if the party wins, there may be a rethink on the CM candidate by the party leadership. In such a scenario, having a substantial number of loyal MLAs becomes crucial to become CM. Each of the satraps has ensured tickets for their loyalists, reducing winnability in the process. "No party can claim ticket distribution is 100 per cent foolproof. But I feel we have, by and large, given tickets fairly. We are all working together too," says the CM. In case the election goes down to the wire, as was the case in 2003, 2008 and 2013, doesn't it make sense to ensure that the Congress vote doesn't split? Was there a proposal to merge the Janata Congress Chhattisgarh (JCC), which took 7 per cent of the vote in 2018, with the Congress? "Dr Renu Jogi, the JCC MLA from Kota and the widow of late Ajit Jogi, is a respectable lady. I have said that she is welcome to join the Congress but not her son Amit. She refused to join without her son, so the matter ended there," says Baghel. The JCC has fielded Congress rebels in several seats. Whether or not it will damage the Congress's prospects is a subject of speculation.

"I FEEL WE HAVE BY AND LARGE GIVEN TICKETS FAIRLY. WE (CONGRESS LEADERS) ARE ALL WORKING TOGETHER"

BHUPESH BAGHEL

Chief Minister, Chhattisgarh

At his constituency of Patan, Baghel finds himself challenged by the Durg MP, Vijay Baghel—also his nephew by relation—but the CM insists there is no fight. "*Rishte mein hum unke baap lagte hain*," he says. Incidentally, it is Vijay who is the only leader from the BJP who has defeated Baghel in 2008 in Patan—a seat Baghel has won otherwise on a trot since 1993. "I don't have an office or a campaign manager in Patan. All the Congress workers are my campaign managers. There are no banners or posters, only handbills," says Baghel, oozing confidence of victory—though JCC honcho Amit Jogi has thrown his hat in the ring there.

At the national level, the Congress campaign on OBC politics is heading for a crescendo. Does Baghel think it will help him too, being the OBC face of the Congress in Chhattisgarh? "We have announced a caste census and the first demand came from the Bastar area," he says. Bastar is a scheduled region but OBCs settled there have been flexing their political muscles, demanding a caste enumeration. They were also opposed to the notification of the PESA Rules as they felt it would empower the gram sabha in favour of the tribals.

The BJP claims there is rampant corruption in the state. Rally after rally, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and home minister Amit Shah have been raising this point—besides Chhattisgarh being a case of lost opportunity in the past five years. "The local BJP leaders are barely campaigning. The party doesn't have a CM face either," Baghel says. "We are instead supporting the fight against price rise by offering subsidies on LPG cylinders, cash transfers to landless labourers, higher paddy prices for farmers, free education from KG to PG, free electricity and loan waivers to women's SHGs." Recently, he announced Rs 15,000 per year for women to negate the BJP's Chhattisgarh Mahtari Scheme under which Rs 12,000 has been promised. How will Chhattisgarh absorb the impact of these 'freebies'? "We have made announcements only after being sure of their financial viability," says the CM.

In Naya Raipur, a new house is being built for the CM to replace the colonial bungalow—formerly the district magistrate's residence. Will Baghel get to live in it? We'll know on December 3. ■